DAY 17

When You Feel Far from God



> *"As the son returns, his father sees him still far away, feels compassion, and goes to embrace him."*
>
> LUKE 15:20

Distance does not always begin with a decision. Sometimes it grows between commitments and postponements. You leave prayer until later, go weeks without opening the Bible, and become used to facing everything alone. At other times, withdrawal follows disappointment or a mistake bringing shame. Thinking of returning, you do not know where to begin.

In the parable of the returning son, Jesus shows a father who sees him far away and goes to meet him. The son's decisions had taken him away, and he now acknowledged his need. The father's embrace reveals mercy that does not wait for a lengthy demonstration of deserving. Return finds welcome before everything is reorganized.

That image may help you reconsider what you expect when seeking God. Expecting only demands may keep you postponing closeness. Grace allows an honest return, acknowledging what happened. You need not deny mistakes, but neither must you make them a permanent barrier. Repentance can be accompanied by hope.

You can also feel distant without abandoning faith's practices. You pray, participate, and read, yet God's presence seems less perceptible. Feelings vary, and difficult seasons can make everything cloudier. Avoid quickly concluding you are guilty. Examine life honestly while considering weariness, sadness, and changes you are facing.

A simple return may be truer than a grand promise. Rather than declaring you will never fail again, set aside time to speak with God and resume a short reading. If something needs repair, consider the first responsible action. If you need companionship, seek someone who welcomes your story without making a spectacle of vulnerability.

Religious experiences may have wounded you, and acknowledging that is part of care. Drawing near to God does not oblige you to return to an abusive or humiliating environment. You can seek safe relationships and a community practicing responsible welcome. The parable's embrace reminds us that mercy must not be language used to cover violence.

The return need not be a performance. God knows the history preceding this moment. You can begin by saying you miss Him, have questions, or want to learn trust again. Let the welcoming father's image enter prayer. Today's distance need not define every day ahead.

TO KEEP IN YOUR HEART

You can return to God honestly and find in grace a place to begin again.

TODAY'S PRAYER

Father, I feel distant and want to speak with You more attentively again. Receive my story, including mistakes, disappointments, and habits that drew me away. Help me recognize needed change without believing every chance to begin again is lost. When weariness makes Your presence difficult to perceive, sustain me patiently. Lead me to safe relationships and faith lived truthfully. May I welcome Your mercy and take an honest step toward You today. Amen.